

The Banking System: Are Students Just Empty Accounts?

Karla Chirica, Krystal Estrada, Jenna Guajardo, Abraham Romero

Department of Teaching and Learning and the Department of Human Development and School
Services, University of Texas Rio Grand Valley

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Dr. Miryam Espinosa-Dulanto

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The Persistent Metaphor

Paulo Freire's banking metaphor, conceived over half a century ago, continues to haunt contemporary education with unsettling precision. The image of students as "empty accounts" waiting for knowledge deposits from teacher-bankers isn't just a clever analogy—it's a diagnosis of what ails our educational systems. When Freire wrote that "education thus becomes an act of depositing, in which the students are the depositories and the teacher is the depositor," he identified a fundamental flaw in how we conceive of teaching and learning. This transactional model reduces education to a one-way transfer of commodities, where knowledge becomes currency and understanding becomes balance.

What makes Freire's critique so enduring is its recognition that banking education isn't merely ineffective pedagogy—it's a form of oppression. By treating students as passive receptacles, we deny their humanity, their agency, and their capacity for critical thought. As Lloyd (1972) explains, banking education aims for domestication rather than liberation, creating compliant subjects rather than critical citizens. The student who memorizes formulas without understanding their meaning, who learns dates without grasping historical context, who acquires skills without questioning their purpose—this student has been successfully "banked."

The Human Cost of Transactional Learning

The consequences of banking education extend far beyond academic performance. When students are treated as accounts rather than agents, several dehumanizing patterns emerge. First, there's what might be called "epistemological passivity"—the learned helplessness that comes from being told what to think rather than how to think. Students in banking classrooms become

expert at receiving, filing, and storing information, but struggle with analyzing, synthesizing, or creating knowledge. They learn to value right answers over good questions, compliance over curiosity, memorization over understanding.

Second, banking education fosters what Chalaune (2021) identifies as the "dehumanization" of both teachers and students. Teachers become mere conduits for predetermined content, their expertise reduced to delivery mechanisms. Students become objects to be filled rather than subjects to be engaged. This mutual dehumanization creates what Freire called the "teacher-student contradiction," where education becomes a power struggle rather than a collaborative inquiry.

Third, and perhaps most insidiously, banking education naturalizes inequality. By presenting knowledge as a fixed commodity to be distributed by authorities, it reinforces existing power structures. The teacher knows, the student doesn't. The curriculum is sacred, student experience is irrelevant. This dynamic, as Mwaanga and Prince (2016) note in their study of sport development programs, replicates colonial patterns where certain ways of knowing are privileged while others are marginalized.

The Alternative: Education as Dialogue

Against the banking model, Freire posits what he calls "problem-posing" education—an approach rooted in dialogue, critical consciousness, and praxis. Here, education isn't about depositing knowledge but about posing problems, engaging in dialogue, and taking action. The classroom becomes what Shih (2018) describes as a space for "conscientization"—the development of critical awareness through reflection and action.

In problem-posing education, teachers and students become co-investigators. The teacher doesn't have all the answers but knows how to ask good questions. The student isn't empty but

brings experiences, questions, and insights to the dialogue. Knowledge isn't transferred but constructed through mutual inquiry. As Firdaus and Mariyat (2017) argue, this humanistic approach centers on "liberation from oppressive systems" and the cultivation of critical awareness.

This shift from banking to dialogue represents more than a pedagogical technique—it's an epistemological revolution. It challenges the very notion of what knowledge is and who gets to have it. In a dialogical classroom, knowledge isn't property to be owned but meaning to be made. It's not about filling empty accounts but about sparking conversations that matter.

Technology: New Tools, Old Patterns?

The digital age presents both promise and peril for Freire's critique. On one hand, technology offers unprecedented opportunities for dialogue, collaboration, and student voice. Social media platforms, discussion forums, and collaborative tools could, in theory, democratize education by amplifying marginalized voices and facilitating genuine dialogue.

On the other hand, as Coppola (2021) warns in his provocative question "What if Freire Had Facebook?", digital spaces often replicate rather than challenge banking dynamics. Social media can become platforms for what he calls "woke culture" performances—virtue signaling, call-out culture, tone policing—that shut down dialogue rather than opening it up. Similarly, many educational technologies are designed for efficiency and control rather than dialogue and liberation. Learning management systems that prioritize content delivery over discussion, automated assessment tools that value right answers over good thinking, surveillance technologies that monitor compliance rather than engagement—these are banking education in digital drag.

The challenge, then, is to use technology not to make banking education more efficient but to make dialogical education more possible. This requires what Keesing-Styles (2003) calls "critical assessment"—evaluation practices that align with rather than contradict critical pedagogy. It means designing digital spaces that facilitate genuine dialogue, that amplify student voice, that support collaborative knowledge construction rather than individual content consumption.

The Classroom as Contested Space

Every classroom represents a choice between banking and dialogue, between transaction and transformation. This choice manifests in countless daily decisions: Do we lecture or facilitate discussion? Do we test memorization or assess understanding? Do we present knowledge as settled or as contested? Do we value compliance or curiosity?

The banking model persists not because it's effective but because it's comfortable. It's administratively convenient, politically safe, and culturally familiar. As Alam (2013) notes, banking education aligns with "socio-cultural patterns that value teacher authority and standardized knowledge transmission." It fits neatly into systems designed for sorting and ranking, for credentialing rather than educating.

Dialogical education, by contrast, is messy, unpredictable, and demanding. It requires teachers to relinquish control, to embrace uncertainty, to value process over product. It requires students to take risks, to voice opinions, to engage with complexity. It requires institutions to value critical thinking over compliance, understanding over coverage, transformation over transaction.

Toward a Pedagogy of Liberation

The question at the heart of our project—"Are students just empty accounts?"—is ultimately a question about what we believe education is for. If education is merely about transmitting existing knowledge, preparing workers for existing jobs, socializing citizens into existing systems, then perhaps banking makes sense. But if education is about something more—about human flourishing, about democratic participation, about social transformation—then we need something radically different.

Freire's alternative isn't just a different teaching method; it's a different vision of humanity. It assumes that people are not empty vessels but meaning-makers, not passive recipients but active agents, not objects to be filled but subjects to be engaged. This vision has profound implications for how we structure classrooms, design curricula, assess learning, and conceive of education's purpose.

As we created our satirical bank classroom video, we were struck by how literally Freire's metaphor could be rendered—and how absurd it appears when made visible. The teacher as bank teller, the student as account holder, knowledge as deposit slips—these images capture the reductionism of banking education. But they also point toward what's missing: the human connection, the intellectual excitement, the transformative potential of real education.

The challenge before us isn't just to critique banking education but to imagine and enact alternatives. It's to create classrooms where dialogue replaces monologue, where questions matter more than answers, where students are partners rather than accounts. It's to build educational systems that value critical consciousness over compliance, that foster agency over passivity, that pursue liberation rather than domestication.

In the end, the banking metaphor asks us a fundamental question: What kind of people do we want our students to become? Accounts to be filled or authors of their own learning? Recipients of deposits or creators of knowledge? Objects of education or subjects of their own lives? Our answer to this question will shape not just our classrooms but our society, not just our educational practices but our democratic future.

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